If the transmission is overfilled, the gears churn the fluid into foam. This aerates the fluid and causing the same conditions occurring with a low level. In either case, air bubbles cause fluid overheating, oxidation, and varnish buildup which interferes with valve and clutch operation. Foaming also causes fluid expansion which can result in fluid overflow from the transmission vent or fill tube. Fluid overflow can easily be mistaken for a leak if inspection is not careful.

FLUID CONTAMINATION

Transmission fluid contamination is generally a result of:

- adding incorrect fluid
- failure to clean dipstick and fill tube when checking level
- engine coolant entering the fluid
- internal failure that generates debris
- overheat that generates sludge (fluid breakdown)
- failure to replace contaminated converter after repair

The use of non-recommended fluids can result in transmission failure. The usual results are erratic shifts, slippage, abnormal wear and eventual failure due to fluid breakdown and sludge formation. Avoid this condition by using recommended fluids only.

The dipstick cap and fill tube should be wiped clean before checking fluid level. Dirt, grease and other foreign material on the cap and tube could fall into the tube if not removed beforehand. Take the time to wipe the cap and tube clean before withdrawing the dipstick.

Engine coolant in the transmission fluid is generally caused by a cooler malfunction. The only remedy is to replace the radiator as the cooler in the radiator is not a serviceable part. If coolant has circulated through the transmission, an overhaul is necessary.

The torque converter should be replaced whenever a failure generates sludge and debris. This is necessary because normal converter flushing procedures will not remove all contaminants.

STANDARD PROCEDURE

STANDARD PROCEDURE - FLUID LEVEL CHECK

FLUID LEVEL CHECK

The transmission sump has a dipstick to check oil similar to most automatic transmissions. It is located on the left side of the engine. Be sure to wipe all dirt from dipstick handle before removing.

The torque converter fills in both the PARK and NEUTRAL positions. Place the selector lever in PARK to be sure that the fluid level check is accurate. **The engine should be running at idle speed for at least one minute, with the vehicle on level ground.** At normal operating temperature (approximately 82 C. or 180 F.), the fluid level is correct if it is in the HOT region (cross-hatched area) on the oil level indicator. The fluid level should be in COLD region at 70° F fluid temperature. Adjust fluid level as necessary. Use only Mopar® ATF+4, Automatic Transmission Fluid.